

Artistic Final Project Connection to Course Material

I chose to create a zine titled “How to Cope with Ecogrief and Climate Anxiety (for UCSB students).” This obviously connects the most to the week three course content. I think it is important to address ecogrief so we can handle the urgent global ecological problems. As mentioned by professor Pellow, many people in power understand climate change, but are too overwhelmed by the reality of the situation so they choose to deny or ignore the urgency. Even if people are educated about climate change taking action can be uncomfortable and emotionally challenging for anyone. Coping with stress that comes from knowing the truth about our environmental crisis is a good first step in productively addressing them. I thought a zine would be a fitting, artistic way to explain how to cope with these challenging emotions healthily.

Creating a zine took me several drafts to get it flowing as smoothly as I wanted. I wanted to start with the message that it is okay to take breaks from news and media to protect your mental health. While I believe it is important to stay educated about what is going on in the world, if it is impacting your mental health day to day, it is okay to take breaks and take care of yourself. I wanted to offer coping skills like the ones mentioned in the lecture on January 21st, since it is easy to say “take care of yourself,” but it can be hard to implement. Professor Pellow mentioned how walking on beach helps him unwind and relax. I know from personal experience that walks on the beach are anxiety reducing, but I looked into research by Q Porschatis (LCSW) that explains how exercise reduces anxiety and included a few tips on page 3 of my zine. One resource from the week three course content that I included on page 4 was the guided nature meditation “Exploring the Body as a Doorway to Sensory Awareness.” I found this activity very calming and worth sharing.

I was also inspired by the readings “Here's how to turn climate change anxiety into action” by Allison Aubrey and Thich Nhat Hahn’s “Ten Love Letters to the Earth.” Allison Aubrey offers some valuable techniques in coping with climate anxiety. One I personally found particularly helpful is her suggestion to write letters to the earth or your future self. I chose to include this advice on page 5 of my zine. Another suggestion for reducing anxiety that I have learned from personal experience is talking with peers and mental health professionals, so I included campus resources on page 6. Katie Maynard, the guest speaker in week 8, shared some resources that I included in my zine. I think volunteering in local gardens is a great suggestion that can help you feel connected to the earth, reduce stress by being in nature, and feel good about taking action to support locally grown food. I included several campus organizations that students can engage with that I believe could help reduce climate anxiety. Specifically, I recommend signing up for the Edible Campus Programs email list since they share events and volunteer opportunities that can help reduce climate anxiety. I conclude my zine by sharing some recent positive developments in climate action. There is a lot of bad news out there, but it is important to celebrate the wins too so you don’t get discouraged.

Finally, the back cover shares the link and phone number for the Counseling and Psychological Services program at UCSB. Since my zine is targeted to UCSB students, I wanted to include local resources in case reading good news, trying the listed coping strategies by oneself, talking to peers, and/or attending events just isn’t enough to handle the emotions that come with climate change education. Overall, I think my zine connects to and expands on my learning from the ENVS 3 course material and goals.